

STEAM ERA

The era of steam and steel changed living conditions, not always for the better. With no gun ports there was even less air below deck than previously, and the heat, noise, and fumes from the engines could become intolerable. Artificial ventilation was only slowly introduced. Many men found the motion of a steamship cutting through the waves more upsetting than the subtler movement of an old sailing ship, with the result that seasickness became a worse problem. The introduction of bunks took a while. It was still common in World War II for hundreds of men to sleep in hammocks hanging in the mess halls and perform their morning ablutions, including cleaning teeth and shaving, in a single bucket of cold water.

BUNK BEDS The African American Corps of Engineers being transported in 1942 temporarily experience the same crowded conditions the average sailor endured, bunking "on the shelf" on canvas beds.

OFFICER'S ROOM This officer's room aboard the 910 ft (277 m) long WWII-era aircraft carrier, the USS *Lexington*, afforded some privacy and had its own sink.



> *"In the cockpit of a line of battle ship, where all the gentlemen mess, they never have any daylight ... dirty screens, cots and hammocks hanging in all directions ..."*
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> **JAMES LOWRY,** *Fiddlers and Whores* A surgeon in Nelson's fleet gives his first impressions of his living quarters

HUNG OUT TO DRY Away at sea for long periods, it was important for crewmen to maintain good hygiene. The French navy in the early 1900s used to allot Tuesdays and Fridays as laundry days, and hoist the wet clothing above the deck to dry.

UNDERWATER

Submarines always presented special problems, being by their nature claustrophobic and cramped. Some early World War I types had no toilet facilities except a bucket. German U-boat crews in World War II normally shared bunks, one man rising for his watch as the other occupant turned in. The boats spent most of their time on the surface, where they pitched and rolled mercilessly—diving often came as a sweet relief, both from seasickness and the clattering of the diesel engine. With only seawater available, most men did not bother to wash their clothes or themselves, and no one shaved. The smell of unwashed bodies and diesel fuel was masked by generous application of eau de cologne. On modern nuclear submarines showers are obligatory—although carried out with the minimum use of water—and bunks are individual, but with nine men sleeping in a room sometimes shared with a missile tube, the sailor's life remains short on the luxuries of space and privacy.





SLEEPING QUARTERS Launched in 1954, the *Nautilus* was the world's first nuclear-powered submarine. In contrast with the cramped crew's quarters on the lower deck, with their three-tiered bunks, the officers' quarters on the upper deck, has a single bed and a table.